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THE SEVEN STEPS TO SUCCESSFUL AI

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Organizations are investing billions of dollars in Artificial Intelligence. Yet despite the excitement, many AI initiatives never move beyond proof-of-concept. Others are deployed but fail to achieve meaningful business impact. ROI is proving elusive. Metrics are about deployment, not value. The common explanation is that the technology isn't mature enough.

That explanation is wrong.

This technology is advancing at an extraordinary pace. The real constraint is organizational readiness. Companies are attempting to deploy AI into enterprises that have not prepared themselves to absorb it. They begin with algorithms instead of strategy, with tools instead of transformation. In simpler words, the cart before the horse.

Successful AI deployment is not a technology challenge. It is a leadership challenge.

After decades leading technology-enabled transformations across global enterprises, I have observed that organizations that consistently realize value from AI follow the same sequence. They resist the temptation to start with the technology. Instead, they build the enterprise around it. With thoughtful preparation, prioritization, and planning.

They typically follow a play-book with the following 7 steps — or variants thereof.

Step 1: They Start with an Honest Culture Assessment

Boards want to know if the company is using AI. Every CEO wants to know which AI platform to buy. These are the wrong first questions. The better question is whether the organization is culturally ready for AI at all.

Culture determines whether employees trust AI-assisted decisions, whether managers are willing to redesign established processes, and whether leaders are prepared to challenge long-held assumptions. Organizations that reward experimentation, collaboration, and continuous learning adopt AI more rapidly than organizations built around hierarchy and risk avoidance.

Technology can be purchased. Organizational readiness is engineered by good leadership.

Step 2: They Align Business Strategy with AI Use Cases

Executives often assemble a long list of AI opportunities before defining why AI matters to the business. Usually, as a knee-jerk reaction to a request from the Board, via the CEO.

AI is not a corporate strategy. It is an enabler of strategy. This distinction is critical. The most successful organizations identify a small number of strategic priorities — like improving customer experience, reducing operating costs, accelerating innovation, strengthening risk management, or creating new business models — and deploy AI only where it advances those objectives.

When strategy leads, technology follows — with commitment and clarity. Purposefully.

Step 3: They Carefully Assess Data

Executives “in the know” in AI-led often describe data as the “new oil.”

No manufacturer expects world-class products from defective raw materials. AI should be held to the same standard. Inaccurate, fragmented, poorly governed, or inaccessible data inevitably produces inconsistent outcomes and erodes confidence in AI-generated recommendations.

Before organizations scale AI, they must first build trust in the information on which AI depends.

Step 4: They Position AI as a Change Initiative

Technology-assisted initiatives rarely fail because the software is inadequate or buggy. They fail because people have not been prepared to change, or they refuse to change.

AI alters workflows, reallocates decision rights, reshapes jobs, and challenges long-established practices. Employees naturally ask whether AI will replace them, diminish their expertise, or fundamentally alter their role. Leaders who communicate openly, invest in training, and position AI as an amplifier of human capability — rather than a replacement — dramatically improve the likelihood of success.

The deployment plan should devote attention to communication, assuaging fears, helping people get comfortable, and showing the before-and-after impact of AI. Pilots should be carefully chosen to visibly demonstrate augmentation, not human replacement.

Step 5: They Measure the Starting Point

Executives are often eager to celebrate AI achievements. Yet surprisingly few establish baseline performance before deployment begins. How can we celebrate arrival if we don't know where we started?

Without knowing today's cycle time, customer satisfaction, cost per transaction, productivity, quality, or revenue, or whatever other metric organizations want to impact positively, they have no credible way to determine whether AI actually improved performance.

Measurement is not an afterthought. It is the foundation of transparency and accountability.

Step 6: They Scale Deliberately, Thoughtfully, Carefully

Successful AI transformations rarely begin across the entire enterprise. Instead, they begin where the probability of success is highest: one business function, one geography, one executive sponsor, one cross-functional team, and one clearly defined business problem.

Successful organizations monitor adoption. The best AI solution create value if employees use it. Early pilots should measure utilization, employee acceptance, customer feedback, and operational improvement before broader deployment. Scaling should be earned through demonstrated success.

Step 7: They Measure Again to Ensure ROI

The final step is the one organizations overlook most frequently. After deployment, leaders should return to the baseline metrics established at the outset and ask a simple question: *What changed?*

Did customer satisfaction improve? Were decisions made faster? Did costs decline? Was quality enhanced? Was revenue increased? Did employees become more productive?

If the answer is yes, scale confidently. If the answer is no, improve the process before expanding the investment.

Organizations that succeed with AI view every deployment as an opportunity to learn, refine, and strengthen the next initiative.

AI: Today's Defining Leadership Imperative

Much has been written about which AI models will dominate, which vendors will win, and which technologies will prove most disruptive. Those are important questions. But they are not the defining questions.

The organizations that create enduring competitive advantage from AI will not necessarily possess the best algorithms. They will be the ones whose leaders understand that AI is an enterprise transformation — not a technology installation.

The winners will be those who prepare their culture, align AI with strategy, build trusted data sources to fuel AI, lead change deliberately, measure relentlessly, deploy with discipline, and allow business outcomes — not technological enthusiasm — to determine what comes next.

In the age of AI, competitive advantage will belong to the companies that adopt it best. "The Best" will come to mean those which demonstrably bridged gaps in strategy or, better yet, substantially and successfully accelerated strategy. Using AI for strategic leverage.

You can be one of "The Best" too. Follow our podcasts and blogs on Responsible AI at @readyaidev

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